



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

Conflict of Interest Policy

International Society of Equity Analysts

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This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

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1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) is committed to maintaining high standards of integrity, independence, objectivity and transparency in all aspects of its activities.

This Conflict of Interest Policy establishes the principles, requirements and procedures for identifying, disclosing, managing and mitigating actual, potential and perceived conflicts of interest involving the Governing Council, officers, committee members, employees, volunteers, Members, certificants, advisers and representatives.

As a global professional organisation representing equity analysis professionals, ISEA recognises that unmanaged conflicts of interest may undermine confidence in the Society, compromise professional independence and damage the credibility of the equity research profession.

This Policy supports ISEA's commitment to ethical governance and is intended to operate consistently with the **Ethics Policy, Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct** ("Code") and applicable governance and legal requirements.

2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to:

- Governing Council members;
- Officers and executives;
- Members of ISEA committees;
- Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows)
- Employees and contractors;
- Volunteers and representatives acting on behalf of ISEA;
- Holders of ISEA certifications or professional designations, where relevant; and
- Advisers, consultants and external contributors engaged by ISEA.

All persons covered by this Policy have an obligation to act in the best interests of ISEA within the scope of their responsibilities and must identify and appropriately manage circumstances in which personal, professional, financial or other interests could improperly influence, or reasonably appear to influence, their duties and responsibilities.

The Code establishes additional conflict-of-interest obligations applicable to Members and other persons within its scope.

3. Definition of Conflict of Interest

A conflict of interest exists where a person's personal interests, relationships, obligations or external activities may:

- influence their ability to act objectively;
- interfere with their duties to ISEA;
- create a reasonable appearance of improper influence; or
- compromise independent professional judgement.

A conflict does not necessarily constitute misconduct. However, failure to appropriately identify, disclose or manage a conflict may constitute a breach of this Policy or other applicable ISEA requirements.

4. Types of Conflicts of Interest

Conflicts may arise in various forms, including:

4.1 Actual Conflict

An actual conflict exists where a person's personal interests or relationships currently conflict with their professional responsibilities or could directly compromise their objectivity.

Examples include:

- *Personal securities ownership* — participating in research, analysis or a recommendation concerning a security in which the Member has a material personal financial interest.
- *Issuer relationship* — preparing or influencing research concerning an issuer with whom the Member has a close personal, financial or professional relationship.
- *Compensation incentive* — receiving compensation that is directly influenced by a particular research recommendation, transaction or issuer relationship.
- *Corporate finance involvement* — participating in equity research concerning an issuer while simultaneously being directly involved in an investment banking, capital-raising or advisory engagement for that issuer.
- *Personal trading* — trading in a security while possessing knowledge of a pending research report or recommendation that could reasonably affect its market price.
- *Commercial relationship* — participating in an investment conclusion concerning a company while having a material financial or commercial interest in a business relationship with that company.

4.2 Potential Conflict

A potential conflict exists where circumstances could reasonably develop into an actual conflict or could place the Member in a position where competing interests may arise.

Examples include:

- *Prospective issuer relationship* — developing a business or advisory relationship with an issuer that the Member may subsequently be required to analyse.
- *Pending corporate transaction* — becoming involved in discussions concerning a prospective merger, acquisition, capital raising or other transaction involving a company that the Member covers or may cover.
- *Prospective employment or engagement* — seeking employment, consulting work or another professional engagement with an issuer or other entity that the Member researches.
- *Investment position approaching materiality* — acquiring a growing personal position in a security that the Member may subsequently analyse or recommend.
- *External directorship or advisory role* — accepting or considering an external board, advisory or consulting position with a company or industry participant relevant to the Member's research responsibilities.
- *Performance-linked incentives* — entering into a compensation or incentive arrangement that could become dependent upon particular research outcomes, recommendations, transactions or investment performance.

4.3 Perceived Conflict

A perceived conflict exists where a reasonable person could conclude that the Member's objectivity may be compromised, even where the Member's judgement is not actually affected.

Examples include:

- *Former employment relationship* — publishing research on a company shortly after leaving employment with that company.
- *Close personal relationship* — covering or making recommendations concerning a company where a close family member or personal associate holds a senior executive or board position.

- *Significant corporate access* — receiving unusually extensive or preferential access to senior management of an issuer that could reasonably create an appearance of favourable treatment.
- *Former client or commercial relationship* — publishing research concerning a company with which the Member or their employer has recently had a significant commercial relationship.
- *Public advocacy or investment position* — conducting research on a company after publicly expressing a strong personal investment view or advocacy position concerning that company.
- *Gifts, hospitality or benefits* — receiving substantial or unusually valuable hospitality, access or other benefits from an issuer or other market participant whose securities the Member researches, even where the Member's analysis remains independent.

5. Guiding Principles

Individuals subject to this Policy shall comply with the following principles.

5.1 Integrity

Individuals shall act honestly, ethically and in the legitimate interests of ISEA.

5.2 Independence and Objectivity

Individuals shall exercise independent judgement and identify and appropriately manage circumstances that may compromise impartial decision-making.

5.3 Avoidance of Conflicts

Individuals shall, where reasonably practicable, avoid circumstances that create an actual or material potential conflict of interest with their responsibilities to ISEA. Where a conflict cannot reasonably be avoided, the individual shall promptly disclose and appropriately manage the conflict in accordance with this Policy.

5.4 Transparency

Individuals shall promptly disclose material conflicts and provide sufficient information to enable appropriate assessment and management.

5.5 Avoidance of Improper Benefit

Individuals shall not use their position within ISEA to obtain an improper personal, financial or professional advantage.

5.6 Protection of ISEA's Integrity

Individuals shall conduct themselves in a manner that does not improperly undermine confidence in ISEA's integrity, independence or professional standards.

6. Duty to Disclose Conflicts

All individuals covered by this Policy shall promptly disclose any actual, potential or relevant perceived conflict of interest.

Disclosures shall include sufficient information regarding:

- the nature of the conflict;
- the parties involved;
- the financial, professional or personal interests affected;
- the potential impact on decision-making; and
- any proposed mitigation measures.

Failure to disclose a known material conflict may constitute a breach of this Policy.

7. Conflict Disclosure Process

7.1 Annual Declaration

The Governing Council, officers, committee members and other designated individuals shall complete an annual conflict-of-interest declaration.

The declaration shall require disclosure of relevant matters including:

- significant financial interests;
- external appointments;
- professional relationships;
- business interests; and
- family or close personal relationships relevant to ISEA activities.

7.2 Meeting-Specific Disclosure

Individuals shall disclose relevant conflicts whenever a matter arises during:

- Governing Council meetings;
- committee meetings;
- working group discussions;
- certification assessments;
- procurement decisions;
- partnership evaluations; or
- other ISEA activities where a conflict may arise.

8. Management of Conflicts

Where a conflict has been identified, the individual shall, where reasonably practicable, take steps to avoid the conflict. Where the conflict cannot reasonably be avoided, the individual shall promptly disclose and appropriately manage the conflict in accordance with this Policy. ISEA may determine and require one or more appropriate measures to address, mitigate or manage the conflict, including:

8.1 Disclosure

The conflict shall be disclosed to the persons responsible for the relevant decision or activity and, where appropriate, to other persons with a legitimate need to know.

8.2 Abstention

The individual may be required to:

- abstain from discussion;
- abstain from voting; and
- refrain from influencing the relevant decision or activity.

8.3 Removal from Matter

The individual may be excluded from consideration of, or participation in, the relevant matter.

8.4 Independent Review

ISEA may appoint an independent person or panel to review the matter or make recommendations concerning its management.

8.5 Restriction of Duties or Access

ISEA may restrict the individual's access to information, systems or discussions, or limit the individual's responsibilities in relation to the conflicted matter.

8.6 Resignation or Removal

Where a conflict cannot reasonably be managed, ISEA may require the individual to withdraw from the relevant position, role, committee or activity, subject to applicable governance requirements.

9. Governing Council and Committee Conflicts

Governing Council members and committee members shall take particular care to identify and manage conflicts of interest arising from matters considered by the Governing Council or a committee.

A Governing Council member or committee member who has an actual, potential or relevant perceived conflict in relation to a matter shall promptly disclose the conflict to the Chairperson or other person responsible for the relevant body and shall:

- refrain from using confidential information obtained through their position to advance a personal, financial or other improper interest;
- abstain from participating in discussions concerning the conflicted matter where appropriate;
- abstain from voting or otherwise influencing the decision where required;
- comply with any recusal, access restriction or other conflict-management measure imposed under this Policy; and
- take any other reasonable steps necessary to protect the integrity and independence of the decision-making process.

The Chairperson, or in the case of a conflict involving the Chairperson, the relevant governing authority, shall determine the appropriate management of the conflict in accordance with this Policy and applicable ISEA governance requirements.

Failure to disclose or appropriately manage a known material conflict may constitute a breach of this Policy.

10. Conflicts Relating to Equity Research Activities

ISEA recognises that Members engaged in equity research may encounter specific conflicts arising from their professional activities.

Members shall comply with the applicable requirements of the Code, including provisions concerning:

- research independence and objectivity;
- personal securities holdings and financial interests;
- personal trading;
- issuer relationships;
- compensation and commercial relationships;
- corporate access;
- investment banking or advisory relationships;
- confidential and material non-public information; and
- disclosure and management of material conflicts.

Members shall ensure that research conclusions are developed independently, supported by appropriate analysis and accompanied by clear and appropriately prominent disclosure of material conflicts.

Nothing in this Policy replaces or limits the specific obligations imposed by the Code.

11. Gifts, Benefits and Hospitality

Individuals covered by this Policy shall not accept, offer or provide gifts, benefits, hospitality or other advantages where doing so could improperly influence decision-making, create an obligation to another party or reasonably appear to compromise independence.

Reasonable and customary professional hospitality may be accepted where it:

- is transparent;
- is proportionate; and
- does not improperly influence professional judgement or decision-making.

12. External Activities and Relationships

Individuals shall disclose external activities and relationships that may conflict, or reasonably appear to conflict, with their responsibilities to ISEA, including:

- Governing Council memberships;
- advisory roles;
- employment relationships;
- consulting engagements;
- ownership interests; and
- significant professional affiliations.

External activities shall not improperly interfere with responsibilities owed to ISEA

13. Confidential Information

Individuals shall not use confidential information obtained through their involvement with ISEA for:

- personal benefit;
- financial advantage;
- the advantage of another organisation or person; or
- improper influence over decisions.

Confidential information shall be handled in accordance with ISEA's confidentiality, privacy and information-governance requirements and the applicable provisions of the Code.

14. Responsibilities

14.1 Individuals

Individuals covered by this Policy are responsible for:

- understanding their applicable obligations;
- identifying relevant conflicts;
- making timely and appropriate disclosures;
- complying with conflict-management measures; and
- cooperating with legitimate conflict-of-interest reviews and processes.

14.2 Committee Chairs and Supervisors

Chairs and supervisors are responsible for:

- ensuring relevant conflicts are appropriately considered;
- maintaining appropriate records of disclosures and management decisions; and
- ensuring decisions within their responsibilities are made objectively and in accordance with applicable requirements.

14.3 Ethics & Professional Standards Committee

The Ethics & Professional Standards Committee shall:

- oversee the interpretation and implementation of this Policy;
- provide guidance on conflict-of-interest matters;

- review significant conflict issues;
- monitor emerging conflict-of-interest risks; and
- recommend improvements to conflict-management procedures.

15. Breaches of this Policy

A breach of this Policy may include:

- failure to disclose a material conflict;
- concealing relevant information;
- participating improperly in a conflicted decision;
- using an ISEA position for improper personal benefit;
- failing to comply with an applicable conflict-management measure; or
- knowingly providing materially false or misleading information in connection with a conflict disclosure.

Breaches may result in disciplinary or other appropriate action, including:

- formal warning;
- reprimand;
- removal from a committee or leadership position;
- suspension or termination of membership;
- suspension or withdrawal of certification or designation; or
- referral to relevant authorities where appropriate.

Where the conduct also constitutes a breach of the Code, the applicable provisions and disciplinary procedures under that Code shall also apply.

16. Records and Documentation

ISEA shall maintain appropriate records of:

- conflict declarations;
- conflict disclosures;
- management decisions;
- recusals and abstentions;
- independent reviews; and
- resolutions.

Records shall be maintained securely and confidentially and accessed only by authorised persons with a legitimate need for access, subject to applicable legal and governance requirements.

17. Review and Continuous Improvement

This Policy shall be reviewed periodically by the Ethics & Professional Standards Committee in consultation with the Governance & Nominations Committee and Audit, Risk & Compliance Committee.

The review shall consider:

- changes in professional standards;
- governance developments;
- regulatory and legal expectations;
- emerging conflicts arising from technology and artificial intelligence;
- changes in ISEA's activities and business relationships; and
- developments affecting the global equity research profession.

The Committee shall recommend amendments to the Governing Council where appropriate.

18. Effective Date

This Conflict of Interest Policy takes effect on the date approved by the Governing Council.